$$E_f = 0$$

According to the law of energy conservation,

$$E_i = E_f \qquad (6.54)$$

Substituting (6.53) in (6.54) we get,

$$\frac{1}{2}Mv_i^2 - \frac{GMM_E}{R_E} = 0$$

$$\frac{1}{2}Mv_i^2 = \frac{GMM_E}{R_E} \qquad (6.55)$$

Consider the escape speed, the minimum speed required by an object to escape Earth's gravitational field, hence replace v_i *with* v_e. i.e,

$$\frac{1}{2}Mv_e^2 = \frac{GMM_E}{R_E}$$

$$v_e^2 = \frac{GMM_E}{R_E}.\frac{2}{M}$$

$$v_e^2 = \frac{2GM_E}{R_E}$$

Using $g = \frac{GM_E}{R_E^2}$,

$$v_e^2 = 2gR_E$$

$$v_e = \sqrt{2gR_E} \qquad (6.56)$$

From equation (6.56) the escape speed depends on two factors: acceleration due to gravity and radius of the Earth. It is completely independent of the mass of the object. By substituting the values of g (9.8 $m\,s^{-2}$) and $R_e = 6400\,km$, the escape speed of the Earth is $v_e = 11.2\,km\,s^{-1}$. The escape speed is independent of the direction in which the object is thrown. Irrespective of whether the object is thrown vertically up, radially outwards or tangentially it requires the same initial speed to escape Earth's gravity. It is shown in Figure 6.19

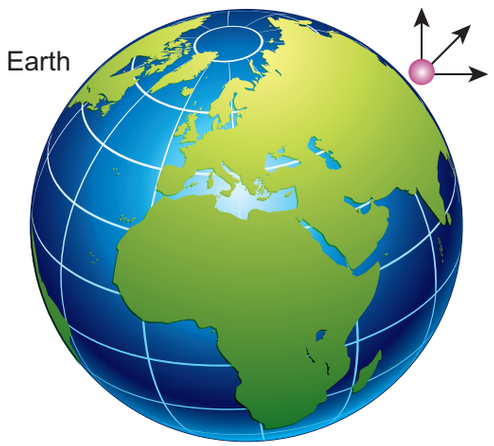


Figure 6.19 Escape speed independent of angle

Lighter molecules such as hydrogen and helium have enough speed to escape from the Earth, unlike the heavier ones such as nitrogen and oxygen. (The average speed of hydrogen and helium atoms compaired with the escape speed of the Earth,is presented in the kinetic theory of gases, unit 9).

6.4.1 Satellites, orbital speed and time period

We are living in a modern world with sophisticated technological gadgets and are able to communicate to any place on Earth. This advancement was made possible because of our understanding of solar system. Communication mainly depends on the satellites that orbit the Earth (Figure 6.20). Satellites revolve around the Earth just like the planets revolve around the Sun. Kepler's laws are applicable to man-made satellites also.

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